British India (1858-1911): The rise of Political Consciousness, Communal tensions & the Bengal Partition

Reorganization by the Colonial Regime post -1857

- THE DEFEAT OF THE REVOLUTION OF 1857 SEES HORRIFIC REPRISALS AND BLOODLETTING BY THE BRITISH COLONIAL REGIME AGAINST THE POPULATION OF THE SUBCONTINENT – RECENT SCHOLARSHIP ESTIMATES RUN INTO HUNDREDS OF THOUSANDS OF INNOCENTS MASSACRED
- THE PEOPLE OF THE SUBCONTINENT ARE ALSO SUBJECT TO AN ADDITIONAL 'REBELLION TAX'(!)
- THE BRITISH RAJ FINALLY EMERGES FROM BEHIND THE FAÇADE OF ITS 'EAST INDIA COMPANY' SINCE THE BATTLE OF PLASSEY (1757)
- COLONIAL ADMINISTRATION IS REORGANIZED
- THE OFFICE OF THE 'SECRETARY-OF-STATE FOR INDIA' IS CREATED AS A BRITISH CABINET POSITION – THE SUPREME COLONIAL AUTHORITY FOR THE OCCUPIED SUBCONTINENT

Reorganization by the Colonial Regime post -1857

- THE ‘IMPERIAL VICEROY’ IS THE DIRECT SUBORDINATE OF THE SECRETARY
- THE FORMER ROYAL HOUSES ARE REORGANIZED INTO ‘PRINCELY STATES’ – DISTINCT FROM ‘BRITISH INDIA’ ON MERE TECHNICALITIES AND LED BY LOYAL COLLABORATORS
- 1861 – ‘COUNCIL ACTS’; VERY LIMITED PARTICIPATION BY SELECTED ELITES AMONGST SUBCONTINENTAL SOCIETY
- THE ‘RAJ’ WILL OFFER MORE POLITICAL ‘CONCESSIONS’ BUT THESE WILL BE TO THE ADVANTAGE OF THE BRITISH EMPIRE BY PLAYING OFF GROUPS AND INTERESTS AGAINST EACH OTHER
- POLITICS UNDER A COLONIAL REGIME CAN NEVER BE NORMAL STATE OF AFFAIRS

Reorganization by the Colonial Regime post -1857

- MERCENARY ARMY – THE BENGAL UNITS ARE COMPLETELY DISBANDED
- MUSLIMS ARE INITIALLY SUSPECT FOR BEING THE 'MASTERMINDS' OF 1857 – BUT NO ALL-MUSLIM MERCENARY UNITS ARE EVER CREATED AGAIN
- THE REORGANIZED MERCENARY ARMY IS CAREFULLY RECONSTRUCTED BY RELIGION, COMMUNITY, CASTE AND SUB-CASTES SO THAT A REGIMENT WILL NOT HESITATE TO FIRE ON ANOTHER COMPOSED OF COMPATRIOTS FROM THE SAME REGION
- BY 1900, THE STANDING MERCENARY ARMY IS OVER 250,000 – STRONG AND CONSUMES OVER A THIRD OF ALL REVENUE TAKEN BY THE COLONIAL REGIME
- THE MERCENARY ARMY IS DEPLOYED AT THE EXPENSE OF THE SUBCONTINENT ABROAD

Reorganization by the Colonial Regime post -1857

- THE FRAGMENTARY NATURE OF THIS MERCENARY ARMY ALLOWS THE BRITISH TO CREATE THE CONCEPT OF 'PERSONAL BONDS OF LOYALTY' (BLOOD AND SALT) THAT SUPPOSEDLY TIE THE MERCENARIES TO THEIR BRITISH OFFICERS AND THUS TO THE *RAJ*
- THE MERCENARY ARMY IS THE MAINSTAY OF BRITISH COLONIALISM IN THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT
- NUMEROUS ATTEMPTS, INCLUDING DURING THE FIRST WORLD WAR, BY ANTI-COLONIAL FIGHTERS TO TRY AND SUBVERT THE MERCENARIES FAIL
- IT WILL NOT BE UNTIL 1941-1943 THAT INDEPENDENCE LEADER *NETAJI* SUBHAS CHANDRA BOSE IS ABLE TO WIN OVER MERCENARIES IN LARGE NUMBERS AND CONVINCE THEM THAT THEIR ALLEGIANCE WAS TO THE SUBCONTINENT AND *NOT* THE *RAJ*

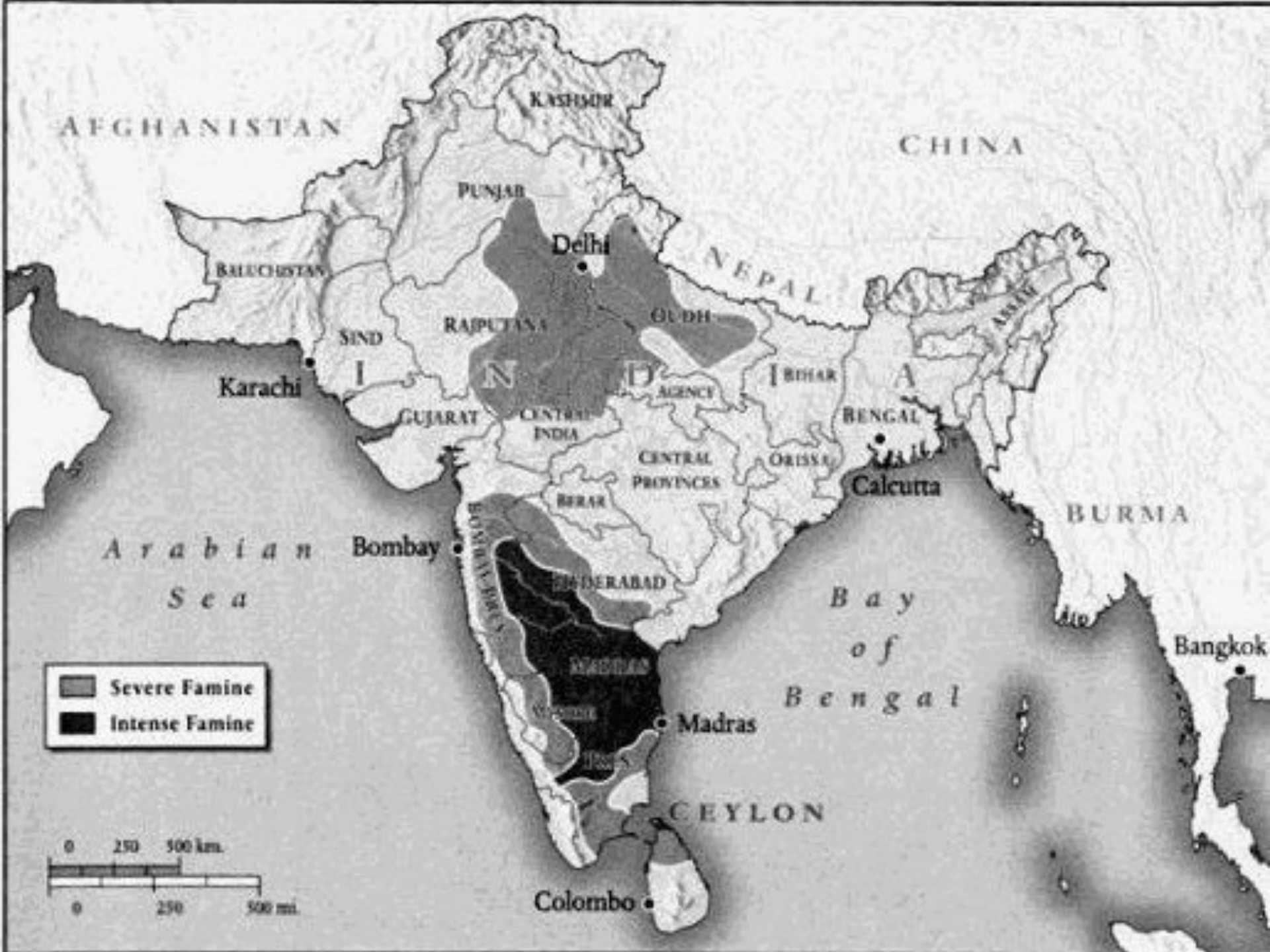
‘Late Victorian Holocausts’ under the *Raj*

- SPORADIC PEASANT-BASED REBELLIONS CONTINUE ACROSS THE SUBCONTINENT
- LIFE FOR THE MAJORITY REMAINS PRECARIOUS UNDER THE EXACTING SYSTEM OF THE *RAJ* AND LOCAL POTENTATES
- MOST ARE ONE HARVEST FAILURE AWAY FROM FAMINE AND DEVASTATION

- 1876 – 1900: SERIES OF HORRIFIC FAMINES, INCLUDING DELIBERATE EXACERBATION OF EFFECTS LEADS TO DEATHS IN THE MILLIONS
- HISTORIAN MIKE DAVIS CHARACTERIZED THESE AS THE ‘LATE VICTORIAN HOLOCAUSTS’

‘Late Victorian Holocausts’ under the *Raj*

- DURING THE 1876 – 1878 FAMINES IN THE DECCAN, THE *RAJ* DELIBERATELY SHIPPED OUT FOODSTUFFS AND GRAIN FROM THE SUBCONTINENT
- LYTTON, THE VICEROY, PROPOSED IMPOSING A ‘FAMINE TAX’ ON THE VICTIMS
- IN THE MIDST OF THE FAMINE, VICTORIA HAD A ‘CELEBRATION’ HELD FOR HER OFFICIALS IN THE SUBCONTINENT FOR HER ACCESSION AS SO-CALLED ‘QUEEN-EMPRESS’
- RICHARD TEMPLE, A *RAJ* OFFICIAL PERPETRATED ‘DIETARY EXPERIMENTS’ ON THE VICTIMS; THESE WOULD BE TAKEN UP BY GERMAN AUTHORITIES IN THEIR CONCENTRATION CAMPS DURING THE SECOND WORLD WAR


AFGHANISTAN
KASHMIR
CHINA
PUNJAB
Delhi
NEPAL
BALUCHISTAN
SIND
RAJPUTANA
OUDH
ASSAM
Karachi
I N D I A
BIHAR
AGENCY
GUJARAT
CENTRAL INDIA
BENGAL
CENTRAL PROVINCES
ORISSA
Calcutta
BERAR
BURMA
Arabian Sea
Bombay
HYDERABAD
Bay of Bengal
Bangkok
MADRAS
Madras
CEYLON
Colombo
Severe Famine
Intense Famine
0 250 500 km.
0 250 500 mi.



Conditions under the *Raj*

- BETWEEN THE 1880S AND 1910S: THE DEATH RATE IN THE SUBCONTINENT PER 1,000 NEARLY OVERTAKES THE BIRTH RATE AT 47 AGAINST 48
- LIFE EXPECTANCY (AT BIRTH) BETWEEN THE 1870S AND 1920S FOR MALES AND FEMALES CAME DOWN FROM 23/25 TO 19/21
- THE 1891 RAJ CENSUS REVEALS ONLY 11/100 AMONG MEN AND 1/200 WOMEN IN THE SUBCONTINENT ARE LITERATE (RUDIMENTARY READING ABILITIES); AN OVERALL LITERACY RATE OF ONLY 6.1%

Conditions under the *Raj*

- THE EXPLOITATION OF THE SUBCONTINENT AND ITS RESOURCES CONTINUED POST-1857 WITH NEW MECHANISMS:
- A SYSTEM OF 'COUNCIL BILLS' OR 'SPECIAL COUNCIL BILLS' WHICH COULD ONLY BE ISSUED FROM THE OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY
- THE COUNCIL BILLS WERE REQUIRED TO PURCHASE SUBCONTINENTAL EXPORTS
- SUBCONTINENTAL EXPORTERS WERE HOWEVER PAID IN LOCAL CURRENCY – WHICH HAD BEEN EXTRACTED BY THE *RAJ* AS REVENUE TAX
- THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT HAD AN ADMIRABLE TRADE SURPLUS WELL INTO THE 20TH CENTURY – BUT FOR THE FACT THAT THE *REAL INCOME* FROM ITS EXPORTS WAS TAKEN BY LONDON

Conditions under the *Raj*

- THE SUBCONTINENT HOWEVER WAS SHOWN TO HAVE A "DEFICIT" BUT THIS WAS NOT THE CASE
  - FOR THE THEFT OF ITS *REAL INCOME*, THE SUBCONTINENT WAS FORCED TO BORROW; THEREBY PRESSED INTO INCURRING "DEBTS" TO MAKE NECESSARY PURCHASES
- SUBSEQUENTLY CLAIMS WOULD BE MADE BY THE BRITISH EMPIRE THAT THE SUBCONTINENT WAS A "BURDEN" ON LONDON
- ECONOMIST HISTORIANS SUCH AS UTSA PATNAIK CONSERVATIVELY ESTIMATE THAT BETWEEN 1757 – 1939; $44.6 TRILLION (IN 2018 US DOLLARS) WAS 'DRAINED' BY THE *RAJ* FROM THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT

Conditions under the *Raj*

- THE EVIDENCE CONTRADICTS THE OLD AND NEW ATTEMPTS TO PRESENT BRITISH COLONIAL RULE FROM 1757 – 1947 AS *BENEFICIAL* FOR THE PEOPLES OF THE SUBCONTINENT
  - IN REALITY, MILLIONS OF INNOCENT LIVES WERE EXTINGUISHED BY IMPERIAL VIOLENCE AND ENGINEERED, MAN-MADE FAMINES
  - ECONOMIC VITALITY WAS DESTROYED – INCLUDING THROUGH DEINDUSTRIALIZATION AND DESTRUCTION OF INDIGENOUS INDUSTRY
  - LIFE EXPECTANCY DROPPED BY A FIFTH BETWEEN THE 1870S AND 1920S
- RESOURCES STOLEN FROM THE SUBCONTINENT WERE USED TO BUILD BRITISH SETTLER COLONIES IN AUSTRALIA, NEW ZEALAND AND CANADA
  - ARMS ACT OF 1878/ILBERT BILL OF 1883

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- NORMALCY OF A KIND RETURNS AFTER 1857-1858
- THE GRADUAL EMERGENCE, OF A ‘MIDDLE-CLASS’, SLOWLY IN PRINCIPAL URBAN AREAS SUCH AS CALCUTTA, MADRAS AND BOMBAY THROUGH THE LATE 19TH CENTURY
- THE RISE OF PRINT NEWSPAPERS IN THE MID-TO-LATE 19TH CENTURY WITH A READERSHIP OVER 100,000 SIGNIFIES THIS TREND
- FOCUS TURNS TO REFORM; IN SOCIAL, RELIGIOUS AND CULTURAL SPHERES INCLUDING THE QUESTIONS LINKED AROUND THE RIGHTS OF WOMEN IN BOTH DOMESTIC AND PUBLIC SPACES

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- WIDOW REMARRIAGE – A CAMPAIGN UNDERTAKEN BY ISHWAR CHANDRA VIDYASAGAR
- SWAMI DAYANANDA SARASWATI FIGHTS AGAINST CHILD MARRIAGE, POLYGENY AND DOWRY
- BOTH ARE ADVOCATES OF EDUCATION FOR WOMEN
- TARABAI SHINDE – WROTE *A COMPARISON BETWEEN WOMEN AND MEN* TO CONDEMN THE OVERALL TREATMENT OF WOMEN DURING THE PUBLIC DEBATE OVER THE RIGHTS OF WIDOWS
- SUCH REFORMERS, WOMEN AND MEN, ARE PRESENT ACROSS THE SUBCONTINENT ACROSS ALL COMMUNITIES AND FAITHS; THE EMANCIPATION OF WOMEN IS A REAL AND PRESSING ISSUE AND NOT A PRIMARY CONCERN OF THE *RAJ*

Swami Vivekananda – the great Hindu religious & social reformer who advocated an egalitarian Hinduism and the universality of worship.

His teachings of social egalitarianism inspired the socialist vision of independence leader Subhas Chandra Bose.



Narendra Nath Datta – Swami Vivekananda

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- THE INCREASING NUMBERS OF PRIMARILY UPPER-CASTE HINDUS IN THE PROFESSIONAL AND COMMERCIAL CLASSES AND EDUCATION, INCLUDING IMMERSION IN WESTERN SCIENCE LEADS TO ABANDONMENT OF TRADITIONAL RELIGIOUS, CULTURAL PRACTICES
- THIS LEADS TO A REACTION THAT BECOMES KNOWN AS *RELIGIOUS REVIVALISM*
- INCREASINGLY, MANY REVIVALISTS INSIST ON FOCUSING SOLELY ON HINDU SCRIPTURES AND IRONICALLY VIEWING HINDUISM THROUGH A MONOTHEISTIC PRISM AS PREFERRED BY THE *RAJ*
- ORGANIZATIONS THAT HAD PREVIOUSLY FOCUSED ON SOCIAL REFORM NOW BEGIN TO TAKE UP CAUSES AND PROJECTS THAT BEGIN TO CREATE FRICTION BETWEEN THE RELIGIOUSLY FAITHFUL; PARTICULARLY HINDUS AND MUSLIMS

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- REVIVALISM LEADS TO AN IDEALIZATION OF THE PAST; WHICH IN MOST INSTANCES WAS IMAGINARY
- IN ATTEMPTING TO REIMAGINE A *PERFECT PAST*; REVIVALISTS END UP TAKING POSITIONS ON SOCIAL AND CULTURAL ISSUES THAT ARE REACTIONARY AND OBSCURANTIST
- A LOT OF THE OPEN-ENDED FOLK TRADITIONS OF HINDUISM ARE IGNORED OR DISCARDED
- THERE IS ALSO A FOCUS ON WINNING BACK CONVERTS TO ISLAM, CHRISTIANITY AND SIKHISM

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- THE RISE OF COW PROTECTION SOCIETIES IN THE 1870S; LEADS TO INCREASING CONFRONTATIONS WITH THOSE IN INVOLVED IN THE BUTCHER'S TRADE, MUSLIMS AND LOWER-CASTE HINDUS
- IN 1888 A *RAJ* IMPERIAL COURT REJECTS THE SANCTITY OF THE COW
- 1893: THE FIRST OF THE HINDU-MUSLIM COMMUNAL RIOTS OVER THE ISSUE TAKE PLACE
- WELL-OFF MUSLIMS, PREVIOUSLY UNTOUCHED BY THE QUESTION OVER COW MEAT, BECOME MOBILIZED
- MUSLIM PARTICIPATION IN CONGRESS BEGINS TO DROP AFTER 1893
- COMMUNALISM: THE PERSPECTIVE OF VIEWING AND TREATING PEOPLE WHO ARE NOT ONE'S CO-RELIGIONISTS WITH DISCRIMINATION, PREJUDICE AND HOSTILITY

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- IN THE BOMBAY REGION, REVIVALIST FESTIVALS SUCH AS THE CELEBRATION OF *GANAPATI*, THE ELEPHANT-HEADED GOD, WHICH HAD PREVIOUSLY WELCOMED MUSLIMS, BECOMES EXCLUSIVE
- THE REVERENCE OF SHIVAJI, THE MOST CHARISMATIC OF MARATHA LEADERS, GRADUALLY TAKES AN ANTI-MUSLIM SLANT
- THE PLURALISM OR NON-RELIGIOUS NATURE OF ISHWAR CHANDRA VIDYASAGAR IS REPLACED BY MORE HARD-EDGED PERSONALITIES SUCH AS BANKIM CHANDRA CHATTOPADHYAY, ONE OF THE LEADING INNOVATORS OF THE MODERN BENGALI NOVEL, WHO MAKES UNSYMPATHETIC PRONOUNCEMENTS ABOUT MUSLIMS

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- NATIONALISM ORIGINATES IN THE FRENCH REVOLUTION OF 1789; THE CONCEPT OF A SHARED, INCLUSIVE, EGALITARIAN NATIONAL IDENTITY WITH A PRIMARY LOYALTY TO ONE’S ‘NATION’
  - THIS OVERTURNS OVER THE CONCEPT OF FEUDAL ALLEGIANCE TO A MONARCH OR RELIGIOUS AUTHORITY LIKE THE ROMAN CATHOLIC CHURCH
  - IN ITS SECULAR FORM NATIONALISM BECOMES A LIBERATING AND DEMOCRATIC FORCE
- SECULARISM; THE COMPLETE SEPARATION OF CHURCH (RELIGION) AND STATE IN PUBLIC LIFE (THE WESTERN DEFINITION, FROM THE TIME OF THE FRENCH REVOLUTION)
- PLURALISM: SPACES FOR ALL RELIGIOUS BELIEFS AND FAITHS IN PUBLIC LIFE

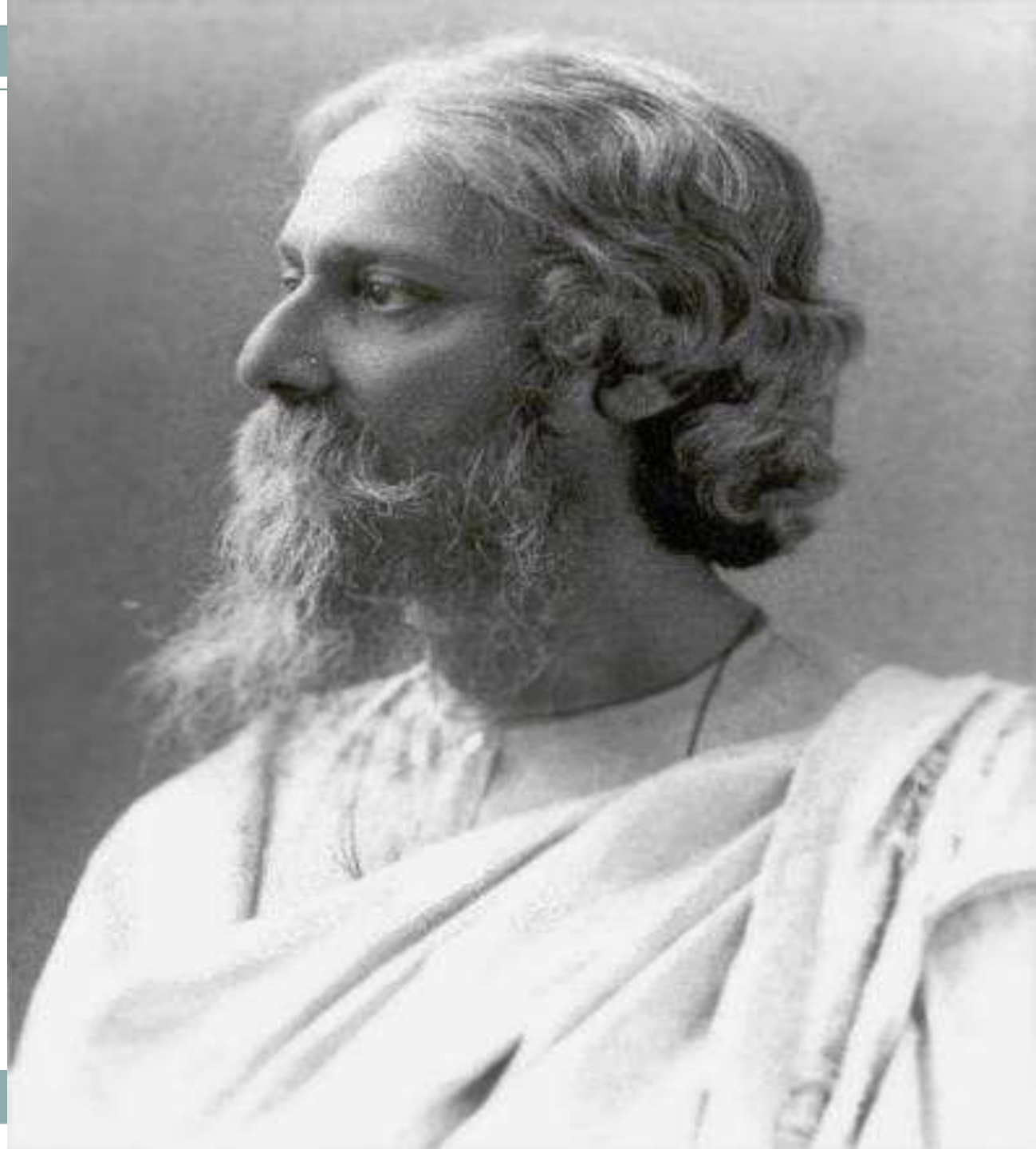
The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- AFTER THE MID-TO-LATE 19TH CENTURY, NATIONALISM IS NO LONGER THE IDEOLOGY OF THE POLITICAL LEFT, BUT IS INCREASINGLY DEPLOYED BY THE POLITICAL RIGHT IN AN EXCLUSIONARY, RACIST, IMPERIALIST FORM
- IN THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT, ANGERED BY BRITISH INTERFERENCES AND INFLUENCES, REVIVALISTS BEGIN TO CONSTRUCT A 'NATIONALISM' THAT IS MORE RELIGIOUS THAN SECULAR; NOT NECESSARILY OUT OF INTENT BUT THE END RESULT IS ALIENATION OF 'OTHERS' SUCH AS MUSLIMS AND LOWER-CASTE HINDUS
- SIKH REVIVALISM (1873 ONWARDS)

The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- THE BENGAL OR INDIAN ‘RENAISSANCE’
- A GREAT FLOWERING OF ENDEAVOURS AND ADVANCES IN LEARNING, ARTS, CULTURE AND THE SCIENCES
- A RESPONSE TO THE CRITICISM DIRECTED BY THE BRITISH AGAINST THE CIVILIZATIONAL LIFEFORCE OF THE SUBCONTINENT
- RAJA RAM MOHAN ROY AND THE ‘BRAHMO SAMAJ’
- MICHAEL MADHUSUDAN DUTT – POET/PLAYWRIGHT
- SARAT CHANDRA CHATTOPADHYAY – DEFINED THE MODERN BENGALI NOVEL & EXPLORED SOCIAL ISSUES
- BANKIM CHANDRA CHATTOPADHYAY – MAN OF LETTERS
- JAGADISH CHANDRA BOSE – PHYSICIST –ONE OF THE FATHERS OF RADIO SCIENCE
- SATYENDRA NATH BOSE – EXPERT ON QUANTUM MECHANICS

Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941): Epitome of the Indian subcontinent's intellectual, cultural & humanist sensibilities. Savant, poet, playwright, first Asian to be awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1913. His significance is indisputable in the subcontinent. India & Bangladesh, two of the present day south Asian states, have adopted his songs as their national anthems.



The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- THE MAIN WEAKNESS OF THE RENAISSANCE WAS THAT IT WAS TOO NARROWLY CONFINED TO THE MIDDLE-CLASSES, OVERWHELMINGLY UPPER-CASTE BENGALI HINDUS
- BENGALI MUSLIM PARTICIPATION IS PRACTICALLY NON-EXISTENT
- FARMERS AND URBAN WORKERS ARE ALSO ALMOST COMPLETELY UNAFFECTED
- THE GULF IS WIDENING BETWEEN UPPER-CASTE AND LOWER-CASTE HINDUS AND BETWEEN HINDUS AND MUSLIMS IN BENGAL
- PERCEPTIVE BENGALIS LIKE RABINDRANATH WORRY ABOUT THE NARROW BASE ON WHICH THE REJUVENATION IS BASED
- A LATE 19TH CENTURY IMPERIAL VICEROY, FREDERICK BLACKWOOD CALLED THE MIDDLE-CLASSES A 'MICROSCOPIC MINORITY'

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- THE INCREASINGLY SOPHISTICATED ARTICULATION OF THE MIDDLE-CLASSES, PRIMARILY OF THE CALCUTTA BASED BENGALI UPPER-CASTE HINDUS LEADS TO THE DECISION OF THE *RAJ* TO ESTABLISH THE INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS IN 1885
  - ALLEN OCTAVIAN HUME
  - CONGRESS IS TO PRIMARILY SERVE AS A 'DEBATING CHAMBER' OR 'DURBAR' WHERE GRIEVANCES CAN BE AIRED IN FRONT OF THE IMPERIAL MASTER
  - THE EARLY CONGRESS – OR FOR THAT MATTER THROUGHOUT MOST OF ITS LIFE UP TO 1947 THE LEADERSHIP IS NOT PRIMARILY INTERESTED IN THE OUTRIGHT OVERTHROW OF COLONIAL RULE – IS NOT HOSTILE AT ALL TO THE *RAJ*
  - IT SIMPLY WANTS A LIMITED EXPANSION OF WHAT IT CONSIDERS IS ITS DUE IN TERMS OF PRIVILEGES

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- SINCE PLASSEY MUSLIMS ACROSS THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT HAD WITNESSED A LOSS OF PRIVILEGES AND POSITIONS WITH THE COLLAPSE OF MUGHAL DELHI AND THEN THE REGIONAL MUSLIM POWERS

- THERE WAS A GREAT DISINTEREST AMONGST MUSLIMS IN INTERACTING WITH THE COLONIAL POWER OR UNDERTAKING EDUCATIONAL OR OTHER OPPORTUNITIES

- THE SITUATION BEGINS TO CHANGE WITH THE INITIAL EFFORTS OF SYED AHMED KHAN WHO ESTABLISHED ALIGARH COLLEGE IN THE 1870S
- SYED AHMED KHAN EXHORTED MUSLIMS TO EMBRACE MODERN EDUCATION AND TO ACCEPT THE OVERLORDSHIP OF THE BRITISH *RAJ*

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- IN BENGAL, MUSLIM DISINTEREST IS GREATER
- FOR EXAMPLE; AN EARLY MID-19TH CENTURY COLLEGE CREATED BY A BENGALI MUSLIM BENEFICIARY PRIMARILY WITH HIS CO-RELIGIONISTS IN MIND HAS LESS THAN A HANDFUL OF BENGALI MUSLIMS A DECADE LATER (HOOGHLY COLLEGE)

- NEVERTHELESS, THERE IS A REALIZATION AMONGST CONSCIOUS BENGALI MUSLIMS THAT THEY ARE FALLING BEHIND THEIR BENGALI HINDU BRETHREN
- ABDUL LATIF – MUHAMMADAN LITERARY SOCIETY (1863)
- SYED AMIR ALI – MUHAMMADAN NATIONAL ASSOCIATION (1878)

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- BOTH THESE EARLY BENGALI MUSLIM ORGANIZATIONS – BUT VERY GRATEFULLY ACKNOWLEDGED SUPPORT FROM BENGALI HINDU ELITES, PARTICULARLY FOR THE ASSOCIATION – FOCUS ON EDUCATION AND INITIAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT FOR BENGALI MUSLIMS BUT REMAIN TOTALLY LOYAL SERVANTS OF THE *RAJ*
- ONE OF THE TRENDS THAT EMERGES IS THAT BENGALI MUSLIMS IN THE MAIN DO NOT BECOME ASSOCIATED WITH EVEN MODERATE ANTI-COLONIALISM IN THE SHORT OR LONG TERMS
- BENGALI MUSLIMS BEGIN TO RECEIVE A MORE SYMPATHETIC HEARING FROM THE *RAJ* WHEN THE IMPERIAL CENSUS OF 1872 REVEALED THAT MUSLIMS WERE IN A SLIGHT MAJORITY
- THIS WAS CONFIRMED IN A RESOLUTION BY IMPERIAL VICEROY BLACKWOOD IN 1885 REGARDING EDUCATION FOR MUSLIMS

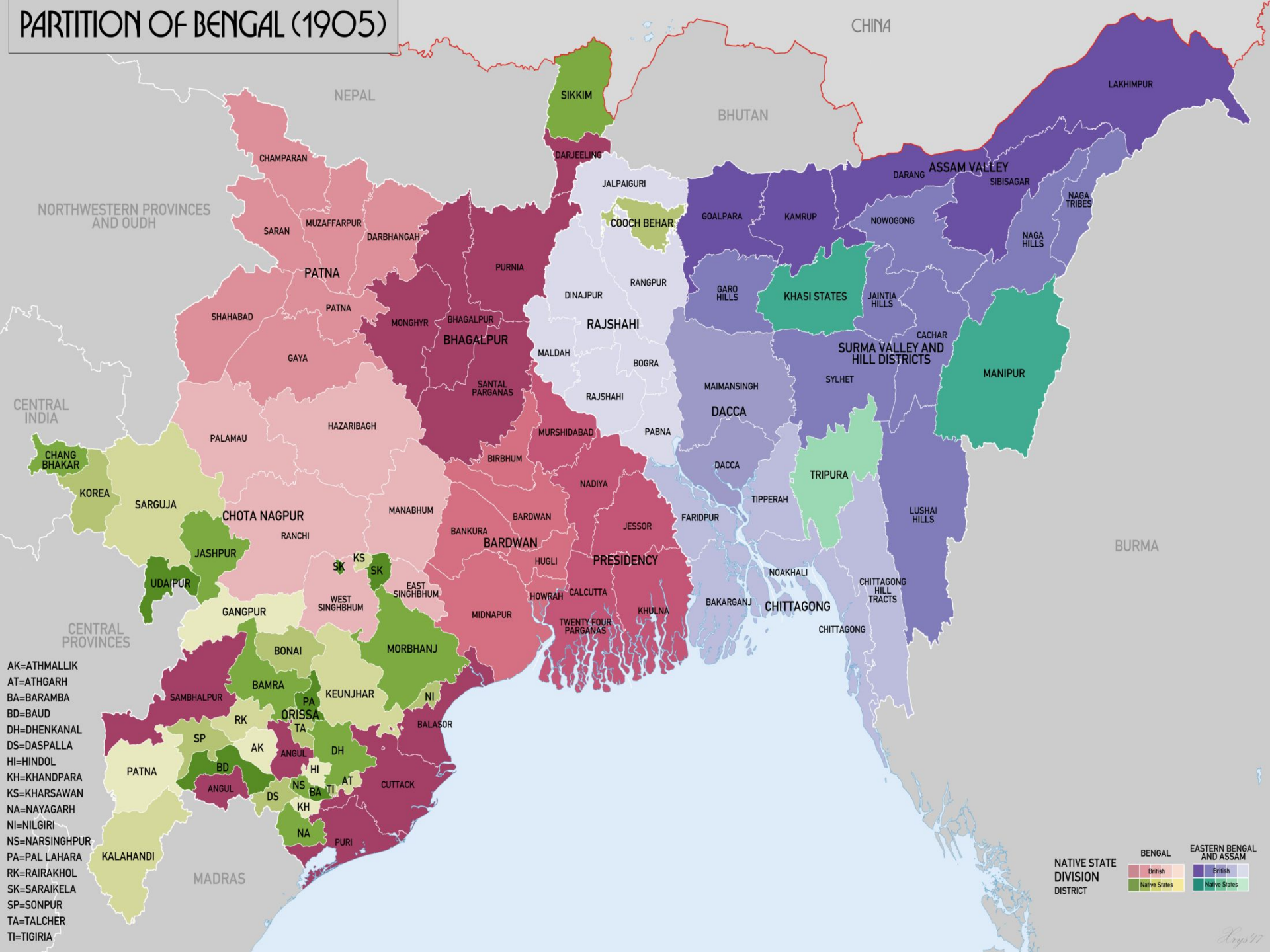
The rise of the ‘middle-class’, reforms & nationalism

- WHILE THERE WERE DIFFERENCES BETWEEN BENGALI HINDUS AND BENGALI MUSLIMS; A MAJORITY OF THE LANDLORDS WERE HINDUS AS OPPOSED TO MUSLIMS AND A GREATER PERCENTAGE OF MUSLIMS WERE TO BE FOUND AMONGST THE BENGAL PEASANTRY
- THERE WERE ALSO IMPORTANT COMMONALITIES; BENGALI MUSLIMS PREFERRED THEIR OWN LANGUAGE FOR LEARNING, INCLUDING ISLAMIC TEXTS
- SIGNIFICANTLY AS WELL, AS EARLY AS 1906 WHEN THE ALL-INDIA MUSLIM LEAGUE WAS CREATED BY ELITE MUSLIMS FROM NORTH INDIA, BENGALI MUSLIMS WERE IRRITATED BY THE REFUSAL OF THE LEAGUE TO SUPPORT THE CONTINUATION OF THE MUSLIM MAJORITY PROVINCE OF EAST BENGAL & ASSAM; REFLECTING THE DIVERGENT INTERESTS OF BENGALI MUSLIMS AND THOSE FROM THE NORTH AND NORTHWEST

The rise of the 'middle-class', reforms & nationalism

- NEVERTHELESS, THE AWARENESS OF A LARGE BENGALI MUSLIM POPULATION NOW LEADS THE *RAJ* TO PUSH AHEAD WITH A MEANS OF NEGATING THE GROWING POLITICAL RESTLESSNESS AMONGST THE MOST ARTICULATE OF THE MIDDLE-CLASSES IN THE SUBCONTINENT
- THE INITIAL REASON PUT FORWARD FOR THE PARTITION OF BENGAL WAS FOR ADMINISTRATIVE REASONS
- THIS DID NOT MAKE SENSE LOGICALLY AS *RAJ* OFFICIALS ON THE GROUND ARGUED IF IT WAS TO BE DONE IT SHOULD BE ON ETHNIC AND LINGUISTIC LINES AND NOT RELIGIOUS LINES
- HOWEVER, ANTI-BENGALI FEELINGS WERE HIGH AMONGST SENIOR *RAJ* OFFICIALS, INCLUDING CURZON, THE VICEROY, WHO WERE DETERMINED TO DESTROY THE POWER OF THE MIDDLE-CLASSES

PARTITION OF BENGAL (1905)



The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- 1904: IN A LETTER TO THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA IN LONDON, *RAJ* OFFICIAL HERBERT RISLEY WROTE: "BENGAL UNITED IS A POWER. BENGAL DIVIDED WILL PULL IN SEVERAL DIFFERENT WAYS. THAT IS PERFECTLY TRUE AND IS ONE OF THE MERITS OF THE SCHEME."
- BENGALI MUSLIMS ARE PROMISED RESOURCES, INSTITUTIONS AND INFLUENCE BY THE VICEROY AND OTHER *RAJ* OFFICIALS
- A MUSLIM-MAJORITY EAST BENGAL & ASSAM IS DETACHED FROM BENGAL

WHILE PARTITION IS OFFICIALLY ANNOUNCED ON OCTOBER 16, 1905 AN ANTI-PARTITION MOVEMENT HAS BEEN FORMING SINCE 1903

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- THE SWADESHI ANTI-PARTITION MOVEMENT CAN BE GENERALLY DIVIDED INTO FOUR INTERLINKED PHASES:
- A MODERATE PHASE, CONSTRUCTIVE, POLITICAL AGITATION AND REVOLUTIONARY TERRORISM
-
- FROM THE BEGINNING THE MOVEMENT IS FRACTURED; A NUMBER OF LANDLORDS OPPOSE THE MOVEMENT, VERY FEW MUSLIMS JOIN, ONLY A FEW OF NOTE
- THE INABILITY OF THE MODERATES, THROUGH LETTERS AND PETITIONS, FAILS TO MOVE THE *RAJ*
- THE NEXT STAGE OF THE MOVEMENT CALLS FOR A BOYCOTT OF BRITISH AND FOREIGN GOODS, THE MAKING OF *SWADESHI* OR INDIGENOUS PRODUCTS

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- THE SWADESHI ANTI-PARTITION MOVEMENT CAN BE GENERALLY DIVIDED INTO FOUR INTERLINKED PHASES:
- A MODERATE PHASE, CONSTRUCTIVE, POLITICAL AGITATION AND REVOLUTIONARY TERRORISM
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- FROM THE BEGINNING THE MOVEMENT IS FRACTURED; A NUMBER OF LANDLORDS OPPOSE THE MOVEMENT, VERY FEW MUSLIMS JOIN, ONLY A FEW OF NOTE

- CONGRESS IS DIVIDED; WITH MOST VERY CAUTIOUS ABOUT THE OBJECTIVES OF THE MOVEMENT
- THE INABILITY OF THE MODERATES, THROUGH LETTERS AND PETITIONS, FAILS TO MOVE THE *RAJ*
- THE NEXT STAGE OF THE MOVEMENT CALLS FOR A BOYCOTT OF BRITISH AND FOREIGN GOODS, THE MAKING OF *SWADESHI* OR INDIGENOUS PRODUCTS

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- THE BOYCOTT IS NOT EFFECTIVE; INDIGENOUS SUBSTITUTES ARE MORE EXPENSIVE AND SHODDIER, COMPARED TO CHEAPER AND QUALITY BRITISH AND FOREIGN GOODS
- TAGORE, IN *HOME AND THE WORLD*, DISCUSSED THE PROBLEMS AND CONTRADICTIONS INHERENT WITHIN THE MOVEMENT
- TAGORE FOCUSES ON *CONSTRUCTIVE SWADESHI*, ESTABLISHING *SANTINIKETAN* ('THE ABODE OF PEACE')
  - NATIONAL SCHOOLS
  - SWADESHI ARBITRATION COURTS
- TAGORE AND OTHER ELITE AND UPPER-CLASS LEADERS EITHER WITHDRAW FROM THE MOVEMENT OR REMAIN FOCUSED ON *CONSTRUCTIVE SWADESHI* ACTIVITIES

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- TAGORE HAD CALLED FOR BETTER RELATIONS BETWEEN THE SWADESHI MOVEMENT AND FARMERS, PEASANTS AND URBAN WORKERS
- HOWEVER, THESE DO NOT MATERIALIZE AND FARMERS, SHOPKEEPERS AND WORKERS ARE NOT CONVINCED BY THE ANTI-PARTITION MOVEMENT
- ADDITIONALLY, THE MOVEMENT USES RELIGIOUS MOTIFS, IMAGERY AND EXHORTATIONS TO GALVANIZE SUPPORT BUT THIS ALIENATES MUSLIMS AND LOWER-CASTE HINDUS
- AS ELITE LEADERS LEAVE, RADICAL MIDDLE-CLASS PERSONALITIES TAKE UP THE LEADERSHIP

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- AUROBINDO GHOSE
- THE OBJECTIVE OF THE SWADESHI MOVEMENT IS NO LONGER REVERSAL OF PARTITION BUT *SWARAJ* OR FULL INDEPENDENCE AND EXPULSION OF THE *RAJ*
- SECRET REVOLUTIONARY SOCIETIES
- ANUSHILAN SAMITI
- REVOLUTIONARY ACTIVITIES ARE ON THE RISE; ALREADY DURING 1905-1907 REVOLUTIONARIES HAVE TARGETED COLLABORATORS AND SPIES
- REVOLUTIONARY GROUPS HAD ATTEMPTED TO EFFECT ASSASSINATION PLANS AGAINST FRASER, LIEUTENANT-GOVERNOR OF BENGAL AND FULLER, LIEUTENANT-GOVERNOR OF EAST BENGAL & ASSAM

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- **'JUGANTAR' ('NEW ERA')**

- **APRIL 30, 1908: TWO *NEW ERA* REVOLUTIONARIES, KHUDIRAM BOSE AND PRAFULLA CHAKI THROW A BOMB AT A CARRIAGE THEY BELIEVED WAS CARRYING A NOTORIOUS *RAJ* OFFICIAL**

- **THE BOMBING STUNS THE *RAJ* AND IGNITES THE ARMED REVOLUTIONARY STRUGGLE WITHIN THE SUBCONTINENT THAT WILL CONTINUE IN ONE FORM OR THE OTHER UNTIL 1938 AND DURING 1942-1943**

- **THE MARTYRDOM OF KHUDIRAM AND PRAFULLA REINVIGORATES THE MILITANT ANTI-COLONIAL MOVEMENT**







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The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- IN THE SHORT-TERM THE FIRST *NEW ERA* GROUP IS DESTROYED BY THE *RAJ*
- 1907: AUROBINDO GHOSE AND OTHER MILITANT LEADERS TRY TO WREST CONTROL OF THE INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS BUT FAIL
- 1908: THE INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS CATEGORICALLY REJECTS THE SWADESHI MOVEMENT
- CONGRESS LOSES ITS POPULARITY; AND WILL REMAIN AT ODDS WITH THE WISHES OF A POPULACE WHO WANTED A MORE DYNAMIC APPROACH TO THE ANTI-COLONIAL STRUGGLE

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- UNEXPECTEDLY, DESPITE HAVING DEFEATED ALL THE PHASES OF THE SWADESHI MOVEMENT THE *RAJ* ANNOUNCES THE REVERSAL OF THE PARTITION IN 1911

- MORLEY, THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA AND KYNYNMOUND, THE VICEROY, INSTITUTE THE SO-CALLED GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ACT OF 1909:

- THE ACT PROMISES THE RIGHT TO FRANCHISE AND PRINCIPLE OF ELECTIONS; VERY VAGUE, NARROW AND RESTRICTIVE
- THE *RAJ* ASSURED ITS MASTERS IN LONDON, SPEAKING OF THE ACT AND THE CONCESSIONS: "…WE ANTICIPATE THAT THE ARISTOCRATIC ELEMENT IN SOCIETY AND THE MODERATE MEN…WILL OPPOSE…ANY ATTEMPT TO DEMOCRATIZE…'

The Partition of Bengal & the Swadeshi Movement

- 27 SEATS ARE NOW OPENED IN THE IMPERIAL LEGISLATIVE COUNCIL; 8 ARE TO BE RESERVED FOR MUSLIMS
- THE INTRODUCTION OF SEPARATE ELECTORATES; THIS WILL FURTHER ENGENDER COMMUNALISM IN THE COMING YEARS

- COMMUNAL TENSIONS WHICH HAD FLARED UP DURING THE SWADESHI MOVEMENT REMAIN UNRESOLVED

- BENGAL LOSES HER IMPORTANCE IN THE SUBCONTINENT WITH THE SHIFT OF THE *RAJ* CAPITAL TO DELHI IN THE NORTH

Readings from *Land of Two Rivers* by Nitish Sengupta

1. BENGAL RENAISSANCE, PP. 232 – 257.
2. GROWTH OF MUSLIM SEPARATISM, PP.278 – 292.
3. FIRST PARTITION OF BENGAL, PP. 293 – 312.